

He was born into a noble family that had recently become rulers of the principality of Venosa in southern Italy, and when his elder brother died in 1584, Carlo became heir to the principality. It was expected of him to marry and produce a family to carry on the line of succession. Although this ruined his plans to become a priest, it did give him the opportunity to spend even more of his time on his particular passion for music.

Dangerous liaisons

Carlo married his cousin Maria d'Avalos in 1586, but within a very short time she became dissatisfied with his complete lack of attention to her, and sought her pleasures elsewhere. For some years, she carried on an affair with another nobleman, Fabrizio Carafa, and although the relationship was common knowledge throughout the region, Gesualdo seemed unaware of the betrayal. That is, until one night in October 1590, when he discovered the couple in flagrante, and, with the help of his servants, murdered them in their bed. It was, by all accounts, a gruesome and bloody crime of passion, with the lovers being stabbed, shot, and mutilated. Gesualdo ordered that the bodies be displayed outside the palace to make their shame public.

Because of the circumstances of the murder and the aristocratic status of the perpetrator, the case was dismissed, and Gesualdo remained a free man. But, of course, the incident had a profound effect on him. He succeeded as prince of Venosa when his father died the following year, and in 1594 he arranged a second marriage, to the noblewoman Leonora d'Este. This was not a love match but a marriage of convenience, and appears to have been